



Richard Cooke

FRACTIONAL CFO / FINANCE DIRECTOR



EXECUTIVE POSITIONING

I work with founder-led £10m–£100m businesses to restore performance, accelerate growth, and increase equity value through disciplined financial leadership, operational transformation and strategic M&A execution.

20+ years leading, scaling and turning around complex multi-site organisations across the UK and Europe, including food, building products, engineered metals, construction and national distribution. I specialise in preparing businesses for investment, sale or strategic options, strengthening financial infrastructure, and delivering measurable improvements in profitability, cash generation and enterprise value.

Specialist in:

- Business turnaround & performance stabilisation
- Margin expansion & cost-to-serve optimisation
- Strategic planning & value-creation roadmaps
- M&A execution, post-acquisition integration & synergy delivery
- Exit readiness, equity story development & investor preparation
- Operational discipline across manufacturing, food production & B2B distribution
- Systems, controls and reporting professionalisation
- Leadership development across finance, operations, supply chain & commercial teams

I operate on a fractional basis (2–8 days per month) or through defined transformation mandates.

WHAT I DO FOR FOUNDERS

Revenue & Growth Acceleration

- Build and deliver strategic growth plans aligned to market, margin and operational capacity
- Strengthen commercial discipline, pricing strategy and customer profitability
- Improve forecasting accuracy, demand planning and sales-to-operations alignment
- Support Boards in defining and communicating a compelling strategic vision to investors and acquirers

Cost, Margin & Operational Expansion

- Conduct full structural cost reviews across manufacturing, supply chain and overheads
- Improve operational productivity, OEE, labour efficiency and working capital discipline
- Redesign processes, controls and reporting to support scalable growth
- Identify and remove non-performing layers, legacy processes and value leakage
- Implement ERP, BI and financial systems to improve insight and governance

Exit, M&A & Sale Preparation



-
- Prepare businesses for sale through disciplined financial improvement and equity story development
 - Lead M&A processes including due diligence, integration planning and synergy delivery
 - Increase EBITDA multiples through operational discipline, recurring revenue development and strategic clarity
 - Professionalise Board reporting, investor packs and governance structures
 - Support founders in articulating long-term value creation to strategic buyers

SELECTED IMPACT

- Delivered full turnaround of a manufacturing group, improving ROS from –10% to +6% in 18 months through cost restructuring, supplier renegotiation and operational discipline
- Led strategic transformation of a national B2B distribution business, delivering 10%+ CAGR and preparing the business for a successful sale
- Built and integrated multi-site food and manufacturing operations, scaling to £90m turnover with strong profitability
- Supported the sale of a food business to Orkla plc, shaping financial narrative and supporting founder negotiations
- Delivered post-acquisition integration programmes including ERP implementation, synergy capture and operational alignment
- Strengthened financial controls, reporting and governance across multiple founder-led businesses preparing for investment or exit

CURRENT & RECENT ENGAGEMENTS

- Advising a founder-led food business on strategic options, operational improvement and investor readiness
- Supporting a manufacturing and distribution group through performance stabilisation and growth planning
- Leading M&A preparation and integration work for businesses seeking to increase equity value ahead of sale
- Providing fractional CFO support to SMEs requiring improved systems, controls, forecasting and Board-level insight

Available for:

- Fractional CFO / Finance Director mandates
- Turnaround & performance improvement programmes
- Growth & EBITDA transformation projects
- Exit readiness & M&A preparation

Available for domestic UK and international travel as required.